

shared objects, and XML. An array is the first method you're likely to use in your ActionScript code. The role of an array is to create a list of data types in your code. For example, you may want to list the colours red, green, blue, and orange. To do this you need to define a new variable with the data type of Array:

- `var colorArray:Array = new Array("red", "green", "blue", "orange");`

You can see in this script that a set of four items have been inserted into the array. You can access the data in the array with the following trace statement:

- `trace (colorArray);`

The "push" property will allow you to add a new item into your array:

- `colorArray.push("purple");`

To remove the last item of an array you can use the Pop property.

- `colorArray.pop();`

What you will find is that arrays are great for managing simple lists. Additional properties allow you to remove specific values, to count the number of values you have, and to sort your lists. For more complex data you will want to leverage the Local DataStorage or XML.

Using flash cookies

The Flash Player can store data locally in very much the same way that a cookie can be stored in a web browser. Flash does not call them cookies, but Shared Objects. An example of a Shared Object in AS3 is:

- `var mySO:SharedObject = SharedObject.`
- `getLocal("myFlashCookie");`
- `mySO.data.now = new Date().time;`
- `trace(mySO.data.now);`

The Shared Object is declared and given a name where it will be stored on the local computer. You can now effectively target data to this space that can be accessed if this computer comes back to this page at a later date.

Manipulating XML with E4X

Flash has supported XML in one fashion or another since Flash 5. AS3 now supports the ECMA XML standard called E4X. You can now more easily step through your XML documents. The following will demonstrate how you can import an XML documents into your Flash movie as a data type.